

QUARTER IN REVIEW

Q3 2026

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Stellar Development Foundation · October 2026

A Letter from Denelle

Third quarter 2026 is one marked by growth and real utility. In Q3 2026, total volume on Stellar reached $33.2 billion, up 71% from Q2. Stablecoin market cap reached $496M, and real-world assets reached $4.1 billion. This growth was matched by both the ecosystem and the network: during the quarter, Stellar ranked second globally by monthly active developers. The network's Tier 1 validator set grew from seven to ten, two protocol upgrades went live, and network availability held steady at 99.99% over twelve years.

Stablecoin volume grew by 121% quarter-over-quarter to $25.1 billion, with momentum accelerated by institutional adoption.
On Sept. 9, U.S. Bank completed a live pilot of USBDC, its dollar-backed stablecoin. It moved value between its entities in North America and Europe, using the Stellar's built-in freeze and clawback controls. A week earlier, USDT0 launched on Stellar with ten partners supporting it on day one. And BVNK, which Mastercard acquired in August, integrated Stellar for its customers. Payments are what Stellar was built for. I expect that growth to continue.

Real-world assets on Stellar reached $4.1 billion at quarter end, up 36% from Q2 and 548% year over year.
State Street Investment Management and Galaxy brought their Onchain Liquidity Sweep Fund to Stellar on Sept. 29. The SEC confirmed in a no-action letter that Franklin Templeton's registered funds can use BENJI - on Stellar since 2021 - for cash management. And BNY funds were tokenized on Stellar through Marketnode in Singapore. The assets are already here. Now it's time to put them to work.

And builders kept pace.
Electric Capital counted 3,922 monthly active developers on Stellar at the end of September, second only to Ethereum, and full-time developers reached an all-time quarterly high of 475. Round 44 of the Stellar Community Fund awarded $4.56 million in XLM, the largest round in the program's history.

The network delivered (again).
Growth only matters if the underlying network can support institutional scale. While total volume reached $33.2 billion and real-world assets hit $4.1 billion in Q3, the network delivered the reliability to back it up: the Tier 1 validator set expanded to ten to include MoneyGram, Figure Markets and Range, and two protocol upgrades shipped (Zipper and Adapter), all while availability remained at 99.99% after 12 years.

Looking ahead: the utility era
Getting assets onchain is the first step. Next: we focus on making them **useful**, **usable** and **used**. Making them usable means they can work the way assets do in traditional markets: posted as collateral, lent, borrowed against and used in repo. We'll consider them used when payments and assets connect, so a dollar that settles a payment on Stellar can earn yield or back a loan without ever leaving the network.

This work is already underway. In Q3, Sentora launched a vault on mainnet, and Chainlink and Pyth brought the price feeds these markets depend on. In Templar, a tokenized Janus Henderson AAA CLO tranche is now posted as collateral.

Thank you to the SDF team and the Stellar community for the work behind this quarter. We'll be in Lisbon for Meridian on Oct. 28–29 with many of the partners in this report. I hope to see you there.



denelle dixon
CEO and Executive Director

Q3 AT A GLANCE

Volume, assets and developer activity grew in Q3

Total volume on Stellar reached $33.2 billion in Q3, up 71% from Q2. Real-world assets reached $4.1 billion and stablecoin market cap reached $496M. Stellar ranked second globally by monthly active developers.

On the network side, the Tier 1 validator set grew from seven to ten, and two protocol upgrades went live. Stellar Private Payments entered developer preview. Network availability remains 99.99% over twelve years.



Network at a glance

Here is where the network stood at the close of Q3.

	Q3 2026	VS Q2 2026	VS Q3 2025
Total Volume	$33.2B	+71%	+62%
RWA Market Cap	$4.1B	+36%	+548%
Stablecoin Market Cap	$496M	+42%	+109%
Stablecoin Transfer Volume	$25.1B	+121%	+314%
Stablecoin Velocity	50.5	+55%	+98%
DeFi TVL	$264M	+35%	+101%
Total Transactions	1.04B	-5%	+4%
Avg Transaction Fee	$0.00012	+46%	-78%
Monthly Active Developers	3,922	+15%	+121%
Monthly Active Developer Ranking	#2 globally	—	—

NETWORK AVAILABILITY (12 YRS)	99.99%

Developer figures from Electric Capital as of September 30, 2026.

Top 10 developments

Behind those numbers, ten developments defined the quarter.

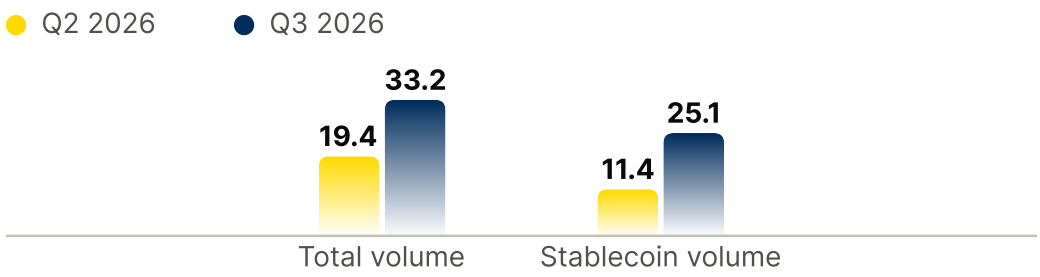
Development	What It means
Mastercard's BVNK integrates Stellar	BVNK, the stablecoin infrastructure company Mastercard acquired in August, integrated with Stellar during the quarter. BVNK's enterprise customers, including payment companies that serve merchants and marketplaces, can now settle stablecoin payments on Stellar.
U.S. Bank issues USBDC	U.S. Bank issued its own dollar-backed stablecoin and completed a live cross-border payment between its North America and Europe entities. Built with PwC, integrated with the bank's existing finance, risk, compliance and operations systems.
USDT0 goes live	Tether's omnichain dollar arrived through the LayerZero OFT standard, with ten partners - including Kraken, Fireblocks and Freighter - supporting it on day one.
A Swiss franc consortium settles on mainnet	A bank consortium including UBS and PostFinance issued CHFD, a Swiss franc stablecoin, on Stellar. It entered live testing on September 8, with SIX and TWINT joining as participants.
State Street and Galaxy's sweep fund goes live	The State Street Galaxy Onchain Liquidity Sweep Fund went live on Stellar on September 29, issued by State Street Investment Management, with Galaxy providing tokenization and distribution and Anchorage providing digital asset custody.
BNY funds tokenized via Marketnode	BNY Investments, with approximately $2.1 trillion in assets, is working with Marketnode to bring select fund strategies onto Stellar, establishing a new tokenised distribution pathway for institutional and accredited investors in APAC.
Onchain RWAs pass $4 billion	Real-world assets on Stellar reached $4.1 billion by the end of the quarter. According to the RWA Foundation, Stellar leads tokenized fund growth this year with over four times the level at the start of the year.
The Tier 1 validator set grows to ten	The validator set grew from seven to ten, with MoneyGram, Figure Markets and Range joining. The set is decided by the validators themselves through their declared trust relationships.
UNDP expands partnership with Stellar	The partnership moved from pilots to institutional operational capability. Building on projects in Haiti, Syria, Kenya, Guatemala, The Gambia, and others, the goal is to embed Stellar as a primary payments rail.
Protocol 27, Zipper, goes live	Authentication delegation and address-bound credentials give smart contract accounts a protocol-level way to grant authorization — the groundwork for consumer-grade wallet experiences.

The Headlines

Total volume grew 71% as banks, stablecoin issuers and fund managers went live on Stellar.

In Q3, several partnerships moved into pilots and production. Total volume grew over the same period, and work began on uses for tokenized assets beyond holding.

Total volume on Stellar reached $33.2 billion in Q3, up 71% against Q2 and 62% against the same quarter last year. Stablecoin transfer volume grew faster still, up 121% quarter over quarter to $25.1 billion, and stablecoin velocity rose 55%.



Two bank-issued stablecoins entered live pilots on Stellar.

U.S. Bank and a Swiss banking consortium began live pilots of their own stablecoins on Stellar one day apart.

On September 9, U.S. Bank announced that it had completed a live pilot transaction using USBDC, its own dollar-backed stablecoin, moving value between bank entities in North America and Europe. The bank has been testing custom stablecoin issuance on Stellar since November 2025.

The pilot tested minting, payment and redemption, as well as freeze, clawback and asset-level authorization. Each of these controls ran at the protocol layer rather than through contract logic written for the pilot. The pilot ran through the bank's existing finance, risk, compliance and operations systems, so repeating it requires no new integration work. U.S. Bank named liquidity management, collateral mobility and cross-border treasury as what comes next.

On September 8, a consortium of Swiss banks began a similar pilot in Swiss francs. CHFD is a Swiss franc stablecoin issued by a group that includes UBS, PostFinance, Sygnum, Raiffeisen and Zürcher Kantonalbank, and it entered live testing with SIX and TWINT joining as participants. The pilot is bounded, with capped participant numbers, capped transaction volumes and testing that runs to the end of 2026. It is one of the first stablecoins issued by a globally systemically important bank to settle on Stellar.

USDT0 went live, and BVNK integrated Stellar.

On September 2, USDT0 went live on Stellar. USDT0 is the omnichain form of Tether's USDT, issued through LayerZero's token standard across 29 connected networks. More than $100 billion has moved across the USDT0 network since January 2025.

USDT0 is minted on Stellar against USDT held on Ethereum and moves between networks through LayerZero's standard. It arrived with distribution already in place: ten partners supported it on day one, including Kraken, Fireblocks, Ramp Network, Bitget Wallet, Lobstr and Freighter.

BVNK, the stablecoin infrastructure company Mastercard acquired in August, integrated with Stellar during the quarter. BVNK's enterprise customers, including payment companies that serve merchants and marketplaces, can now settle stablecoin payments on Stellar. Marqeta provides the card issuance infrastructure and that volume settles through BVNK.

Card spending through these rails reaches merchants that already accept cards, with no integration required on the merchant side.

Tokenized funds moved closer to collateral use.

Tokenized money market funds have been on Stellar since 2021, and their primary uses to date have been yield and operational efficiency. The next step is using them as collateral.

In a repo trade, an institution borrows cash against an asset it owns and agrees to buy it back, often within the same day. Doing that with a tokenized fund requires an asset built for cash management, a price a lender can verify independently, a custodian that can hold it, and contracts that move it.

On September 29, the State Street Galaxy Onchain Liquidity Sweep Fund (SWEEP) went live on Stellar. State Street Investment Management issues it, Galaxy provides the tokenization technology and distribution, Anchorage provides digital asset custody, State Street Bank and Trust Company holds the fund's securities, and NAV Consulting serves as transfer agent. Chainlink supports its pricing and reserve data services.

With SWEEP live, the conditions for an onchain repo trade on Stellar are now largely in place: a fund built for cash management, live on the network, with independent pricing and institutional custody behind it. The vaults and lending markets covered in Section 5 are the next building block.

September 2026 - assets, pricing, and a fund



The Network

Two protocol upgrades shipped while oracle, custody and validator coverage expanded.

Q3 delivered two protocol upgrades and the oracles, custody support and governance that institutions ask about improved alongside them.

Two protocol upgrades shipped during the quarter.

Protocol 27, Zipper, was voted and live on mainnet on July 8. Authentication delegation gives smart contract accounts a protocol-level way to grant authorization to other addresses, so a provider can change who is able to act on an account without changing the account itself. Address-bound credentials tie each signature to the account it was issued for, so a provider can safely operate many customer accounts from shared key infrastructure.

Protocol 28, Adapter, went live on September 16. Under Adapter, consensus can begin before a transaction set has fully arrived and can drop a late set rather than stall, which lowers the latency a payment product runs against. A fleet of contracts sharing one executable reference can be upgraded in a single atomic change, so a fix reaches every affected contract at once rather than one at a time. It also adds new functions that developers can use to make it easier to handle missing or unexpected data fields in smart contracts, which supports long-term maintenance of integrations.

In August, SDF published a developer preview of Stellar Private Payments, built by Nethermind, which uses zero-knowledge proofs to keep counterparties private while leaving deposits and withdrawals visible. It is currently running on testnet. This complements the confidential token work previewed in June rather than replacing it.

Governance, pricing, custody and connectivity updates.

Institutions evaluating a network typically look at four areas: governance, pricing for the assets they hold, custody support, and connectivity to their existing systems. Each advanced in Q3.

Governance. In August, MoneyGram, Figure Markets and Range joined the Tier 1 validator set, taking it from seven to ten. The additions include regulated institutions and specialists: MoneyGram moves remittances, Figure lends, and Range monitors chains in real time. Stellar validators do not earn rewards; these organizations run validators because their businesses depend on the network.

Pricing. Pyth Pro went live on September 8, pulling prices directly from exchanges and market makers rather than aggregating third-party sources and opening its full catalog of feeds at launch. Chainlink shipped Data Streams and deployed Data Feeds to mainnet on September 28, giving builders the price data that lending markets, derivatives, automated liquidations and synthetic assets depend on. A repo desk cannot lend against an asset whose value it cannot independently verify at the moment of the trade. Any collateral use of a tokenized fund on Stellar will depend on oracles that shipped in the final weeks of the quarter.

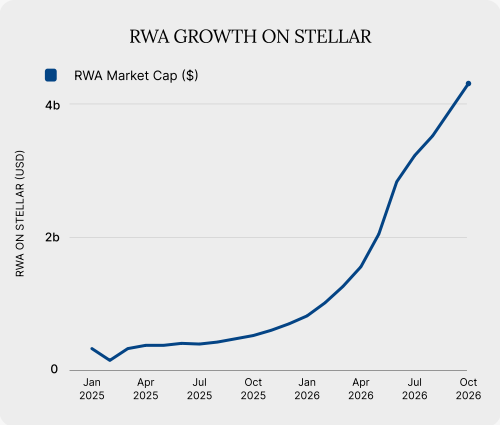
Custody. Fireblocks demonstrated contract-address and SEP-41 token support in September, which lets an institutional custodian hold assets issued through Soroban rather than classic assets alone. This capability supports planned future partner deployments.

Connectivity. LayerZero went live on July 17 and carries USDT0. In early September, Nuvanté announced a stablecoin clearing prototype built on Stellar and tested inside the Bank of England's RTGS Synchronisation Lab, covering stablecoin-to-stablecoin and stablecoin-to-fiat issuance and redemption through a neutral clearing layer.

Assets and Deployment

Tokenized assets reached $4.1 billion, and the first uses beyond holding are being built.

Tokenized real-world assets on Stellar stood at $4.1 billion at the close of Q3, up 36% against Q2 and 548% against Q3 2025. Two assets drove most of the quarter's growth: Tradable's tokenized private credit, which was new this quarter, and continued inflows to the Spiko Amundi overnight swap fund.



Access to tokenized funds expanded in the U.S., Europe and Asia.

Franklin Templeton's BENJI has run on Stellar since 2021. In August the SEC's Division of Investment Management issued a no-action letter confirming that the firm's registered mutual funds and ETFs may use BENJI for cash management. This expands the set of institutions permitted to hold it. Franklin Templeton made a similar move in Europe, registering grBenji as a Luxembourg UCITS share class for third-party distribution, now live on 21X.

In Asia, Marketnode announced in August that it will offer BNY Investments funds on Stellar, with Marketnode acting as the tokenization and distribution platform. Together, these developments expand access to tokenized funds on Stellar for institutions in the United States, Europe and Asia.

Protocols offer a route that does not need an institutional counterparty.

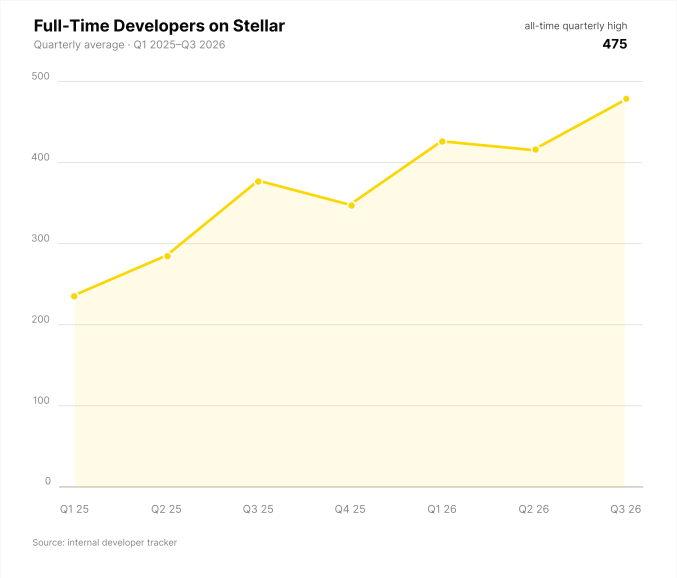
Sentora launched three lock-up vaults on mainnet in Q2 and combined (XLM, USDC, PYUSD) they hold more than $50 million value. In Templar, a new lending venue, deJAAA - Janus Henderson's DeFi-enabled AAA CLO tranche - is posted as collateral. New entrant Templar and established player Blend are venues where an asset can be posted and borrowed against without an institutional counterparty on the other side. The route from issuance to use now exists on the network, and the volumes will show whether institutions take it.

The Developer Ecosystem

Full-time developers reached an all-time high.

Assets reach users through the products and services developers build. In Q3, developer activity on Stellar continued to grow.

By September 30, Electric Capital counted 3,922 monthly active developers on the network, and the Q3 average of 3,661 was up 170% year over year. That kept Stellar second among all blockchains for monthly active developers, behind only Ethereum. More of those developers are also staying: an average of 475 worked on Stellar full time in Q3, an all-time quarterly high and 30% more than a year ago.



Drivers of developer growth.

Two factors contributed. First, developers are building practical applications, particularly in markets where financial access is limited. The SDF accelerator with CV Labs drew 226 applications for ten spots, and most of the cohort is building payments infrastructure. One example is Saleem, which moves stablecoin payments over USSD and SIM Toolkit to people who have neither a smartphone nor a bank account. Rise In's activations brought the same opportunity to developers in Turkey, India, Indonesia, Vietnam and the Philippines, markets where many people still lack affordable access to financial services.

Second, new capabilities such as zero-knowledge proofs and agentic payments are drawing developers to the network.

Participation in developer programs continues to grow.

Stellar Hacks, SDF's series of online hackathons, set a new participation record. The Real-World ZK hackathon, which wrapped in July, drew 747 registered builders and more than 380 projects, up from 258 for the agents hackathon before it. Participants reported that building with ZK on Stellar was accessible, and the winning team came from the XRPL ecosystem.

Between events, the bounty programs run by Drips and GrantFox give developers a steady way to keep building by paying them each month for real contributions to open-source Stellar projects. Drips Waves averaged roughly 4,100 developers a month in Q3, and GrantFox campaigns about 1,600. These programs also show the strongest retention: nearly every developer they bring in has a verifiable GitHub identity, and around 70% come back for another wave or program.

When those builders are ready for funding, Instawards provide fast-track funding. By September 1, the program had made 143 awards totaling $707,900, more than double where it stood at the end of June.

Stellar Community Fund sets new records.

The Stellar Community Fund, which supports startups as they build, launch, and grow, set two program records in Q3. Round 44 was the largest in the program's history, awarding $4.56 million worth of XLM. Weeks later, Round 45 drew the most submissions ever, with 218. Together, the two rounds funded 86 projects with about $8.6 million worth of XLM, chosen by community voters and across the following use cases:

- **Payments:** Minisend connects Stellar to M-Pesa and Airtel Money, Azza moves payments through WhatsApp, and Iomi. bridges West African CFA francs to USDC.
- **DeFi:** Lucent is building a collateralized debt protocol and LumAgg is building a DEX aggregator.
- **Real-world assets:** Balance brings institutional custody to Stellar and Pods is building a settlement primitive for tokenized assets.
- **The frontier:** ZKELLA is building a confidential-finance layer for Soroban, and three x402 facilitators were funded to support payments made by AI agents.

Distribution, Region by Region

Activity is not concentrated in one market.

Latin America.
Cobre moved cross-border settlement for its enterprise clients onto Stellar in Q3, carrying live commercial volume rather than test traffic. NoxPay passed $788 million since launching in mid-July, and the Lumx corridor connecting Brazilian reais to dollars went live in August.

Stellar House São Paulo on August 10 brought a representative of the Central Bank of Brazil into a private discussion alongside José Fernández da Ponte, SDF's President and Chief Growth Officer. Brazil's securities regulator has since published a draft resolution for its DLT pilot, with Stellar positioned as one of the public distribution layers. Stellar is also part of the CVM (Brazil's Securities and Exchange Commission) task force and has submitted a joint proposal in collaboration with the ABToken trade association.

Europe.
The CHFD consortium entered live testing on September 8, adding SIX and TWINT to a participant group that already included UBS, PostFinance, Sygnum, Raiffeisen and Zürcher Kantonalbank. In the UK, Nuvanté tested a stablecoin clearing prototype built on Stellar inside the Bank of England's RTGS Synchronisation Lab. Spiko, which issues across five networks, increased holdings on Stellar to $1.7B, more than on the other four combined.

Africa.
The Stellar and CV Labs accelerator convened its cohort in Cape Town, and Nigeria's developer community remains the deepest on the network. Ghanaian startup, Seevcash, raised $333,000 from SCF to expand their remittance platform. By executive order, Nigeria established a Virtual Asset Council to improve inter-agency collaboration while maintaining existing statutory mandates. Ghana similarly established a Virtual Assets Coordination Council for the same purpose. South Africa's Reserve Bank and National Treasury published a draft Crypto Asset Manual for Crossborder Activities.

Asia-Pacific.
Kenanga's MYR and Shariah-compliant MYR money market funds - already live on Stellar - with work underway to tokenise and distribute funds from other major asset issuers, using Kenanga's tokenization and distribution platform to broaden access to regulated onchain assets in Malaysia. In Singapore, BNY Investments' USD money market fund is live on Stellar and distributed through Marketnode, creating a pathway for APAC investors to access global institutional assets onchain.

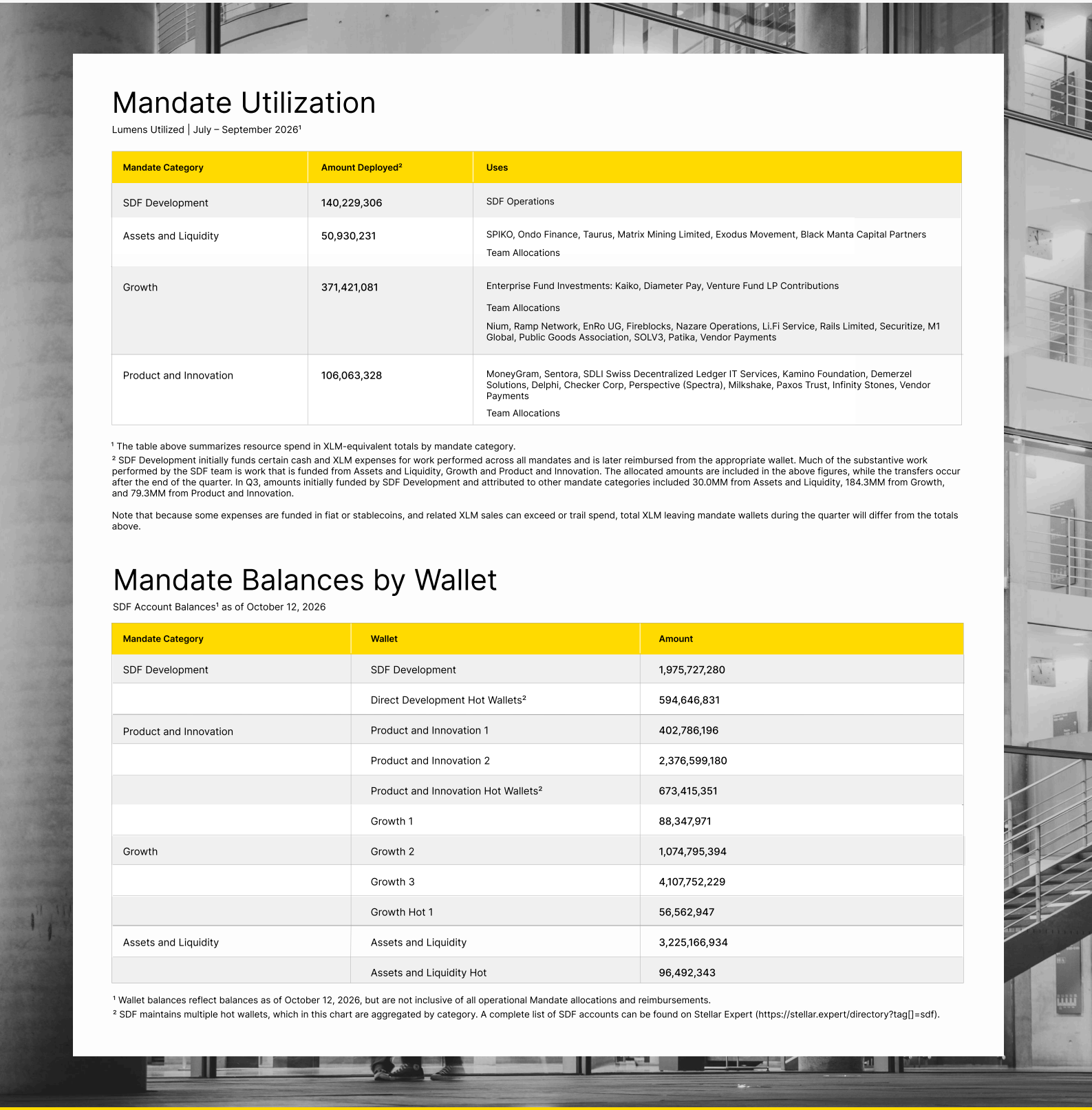
Middle East and Turkey.
BiLira went live with USDT0, dollar deposits and withdrawals in early September, and Turkey continued to generate more Instawards submissions than any other market. Zodia Markets, backed by Standard Chartered, is working with Stellar to advance the use of stablecoins in institutional finance. In Syria, UNDP cash-for-work payments are running in Aleppo, where the cost of getting funds to recipients fell from roughly 10% of the amount disbursed to roughly 2%.



Mandate and Distribution

Where the lumens went.

SDF is a non-profit whose mission is to create equitable access to the global financial system. The Foundation has no shareholders, and decisions are driven by the mission. It holds roughly 14.7 billion lumens, generated when the Stellar network launched, all of which will be used over time to develop and grow the network. A full accounting of every wallet address that holds those funds, and how they are being used, is published in real time on SDF's mandate page.



Mandate Utilization

Lumens Utilized | July – September 2026[1]

Mandate Category	Amount Deployed[2]	Uses
SDF Development	140,229,306	SDF Operations
Assets and Liquidity	50,930,231	SPIKO, Ondo Finance, Taurus, Matrix Mining Limited, Exodus Movement, Black Manta Capital Partners Team Allocations
Growth	371,421,081	Enterprise Fund Investments: Kaiko, Diameter Pay, Venture Fund LP Contributions Team Allocations Nium, Ramp Network, EnRo UG, Fireblocks, Nazare Operations, Li.Fi Service, Rails Limited, Securitize, M1 Global, Public Goods Association, SOLV3, Patika, Vendor Payments
Product and Innovation	106,063,328	MoneyGram, Sentora, SDLI Swiss Decentralized Ledger IT Services, Kamino Foundation, Demerzel Solutions, Delphi, Checker Corp, Perspective (Spectra), Milkshake, Paxos Trust, Infinity Stones, Vendor Payments Team Allocations

[1] The table above summarizes resource spend in XLM-equivalent totals by mandate category.

[2] SDF Development initially funds certain cash and XLM expenses for work performed across all mandates and is later reimbursed from the appropriate wallet. Much of the substantive work performed by the SDF team is work that is funded from Assets and Liquidity, Growth and Product and Innovation. The allocated amounts are included in the above figures, while the transfers occur after the end of the quarter. In Q3, amounts initially funded by SDF Development and attributed to other mandate categories included 30.0MM from Assets and Liquidity, 184.3MM from Growth, and 79.3MM from Product and Innovation.

Note that because some expenses are funded in fiat or stablecoins, and related XLM sales can exceed or trail spend, total XLM leaving mandate wallets during the quarter will differ from the totals above.

Mandate Balances by Wallet

SDF Account Balances[1] as of October 12, 2026

Mandate Category	Wallet	Amount
SDF Development	SDF Development	1,975,727,280
	Direct Development Hot Wallets[2]	594,646,831
Product and Innovation	Product and Innovation 1	402,786,196
	Product and Innovation 2	2,376,599,180
	Product and Innovation Hot Wallets[2]	673,415,351
	Growth 1	88,347,971
Growth	Growth 2	1,074,795,394
	Growth 3	4,107,752,229
	Growth Hot 1	56,562,947
Assets and Liquidity	Assets and Liquidity	3,225,166,934
	Assets and Liquidity Hot	96,492,343

[1] Wallet balances reflect balances as of October 12, 2026, but are not inclusive of all operational Mandate allocations and reimbursements.

[2] SDF maintains multiple hot wallets, which in this chart are aggregated by category. A complete list of SDF accounts can be found on Stellar Expert (https://stellar.expert/directory?tag[]=sdf).